BIHAR

NITISH DOES A JOB ON TEJASWI

By Amitabh Srivastava



ANI

JOIN THE FORCE CM Nitish hands out an appointment letter in Patna, Feb. 4

In the 2020 Bihar assembly election, the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) and its young chief, Tejaswi Yadav, came tantalisingly close to forming a government, missing the mark by just 12 seats. The wave of support was largely sparked by a single, resonant promise: one million jobs.

Fast forward five years, and as Bihar braces for another electoral battle later this year, chief minister Nitish Kumar is looking to appropriate Tejaswi's script. Full-page newspaper advertisements are already out with the slogan '*Rojgar matlab Nitish sarkar* (Employment means Nitish government)', alongside images of the CM distributing appointment letters at public events. Most recently, on February 8, Nitish handed appointment letters to 1,007 new agricultural department employees in Patna. Days earlier, over 6,000 junior engineers had received similar letters.

Nitish claims his government has already delivered 900,000 jobs out of a targeted 1.2 million, with another 200,000 set to materialise before the polls. The timing couldn't be better. Young voters in the 18-29 age group constitute a formidable 22.1 per cent of Bihar's electorate—over 28 million people. This aspirational demographic, yearning for economic stability, has enough heft to sway electoral outcomes. In 2020, it was with this cohort that Tejaswi's promise of 1 million government jobs had resonated, boosting RJD numbers. With the 2025 election just months away, it's natural that competition for this key demographic is heating up: if anything, jobs are even more of a pivotal issue now than in 2020.

WORK FOR VOTES

- **With polls coming up, CM Nitish Kumar out to appropriate RJD's 2020 poll promise of 1 mn govt jobs**
- **Govt claims 900,000 jobs delivered out of target of 1.2 million; young voters (18-29 age group) make up 22% of Bihar's population**

In Bihar's symbolism-laden political arena, restoring Nitish's image as the 'architect of aspiration' is crucial for the Janata Dal (United), or JD(U), if it wants to neutralise Tejaswi's advantage. The CM's I-Day pledge in 2024 to create 1.2 million jobs forms the bedrock of this attempt. "Before 2005, the condition of Bihar was pathetic, and everyone is well aware of it," Nitish remarked on February 4, contrasting his tenure with the RJD's alleged mismanagement in the past. The subtext was clear: under Nitish, Bihar has progressed incrementally, while a Tejaswi-led regime risks a return to regression.

The political longevity of Nitish Kumar defies conventional logic. His Kurmi caste represents just 2.9 per cent of the population—a tenuous base by any measure. Yet, through a carefully cultivated coalition of Extremely Backward Classes, Mahadalits and Luv-Kush (Kurmi-Kushwaha) voters, he commands the loyalty of over 36 per cent of the electorate. This is his bulwark against challenges from both ally BJP and the RJD. In 2020, Nitish faced a resurgent RJD and the disruptive Lok Janshakti Party under Chirag Paswan, an allegedly BJP-backed spoiler. Despite this, the JD(U) retained 32.8 per cent of the vote in its contested seats.

The 2025 election is not just a battle for another term. Nitish's poll-eve jobs bonanza is an attempt to secure his governance legacy along with his future hold on government. His alliance-switching, often criticised as opportunistic, has ironically solidified his indispensability. Both the BJP and the RJD grudgingly concede Nitish's presence holds the key to power in Bihar. Since 2005, every government in the state has revolved around the 73-year-old leader. Will that enduring centrality continue into a tenth term? Bihar's voting public will decide. ■